Climbing The Ladder

When the fighting was all over in Berlin and the shells quit exploding, Honecker resurfaced. Over the years, a multitude of conflicting stories have been published concerning the period between his gaining freedom and rejoining his communist cadres.1 However, it is almost certain he lingered at Charlotte's apartment at 37 Landsberger Straße for a week, before emerging onto the streets of Berlin. After a chance encounter with former comrade Hans Mahle, he was introduced to Walter Ulbricht, the leader of German communists in exile who had been preparing in the Soviet Union for the establishment of a (communist) post-war Germany.

After the Nazi surrender, Germany was split into four occupation sectors and Berlin into four zones. The USA, USSR, United Kingdom and France held supreme authority, while the Commanders-in-Chiefs of the occupying powers held almost absolute authority across the land. Western Allies moved into Berlin in June 1945, a month after the Russians had occupied the city.

During the first month of sole Russian occupation, Berlin resembled a 'picture of hell', according to Ulbricht's youngest associate, Wolfgang Leonhard. There were 'flaking ruins and starving people shambling around in tattered clothing … all of them looking terribly tired, hungry, tense and demoralised.'2 Ulbricht's daily sessions at the 'Rose' restaurant became a Mecca for functionaries released from Nazi prisons looking for jobs. Ulbricht later explained:3

Our advantage lay in being well prepared. When the Soviet troops crossed the Vistula, a commission had already been set up within our party leadership to plan the first essential measures in the struggle against Hitlerite fascism. We worked